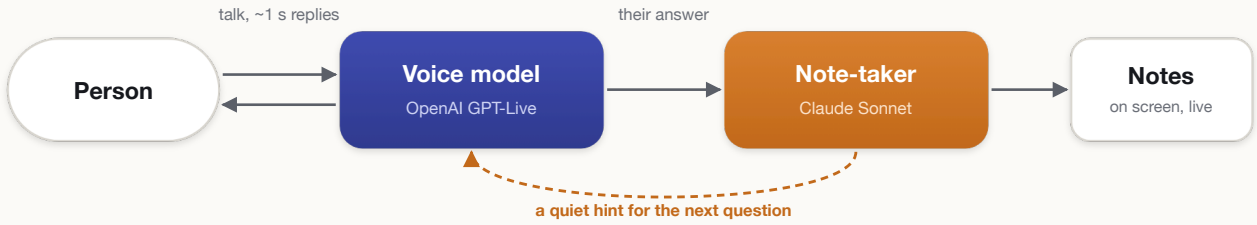
VIVEN AI · INTERVIEWER · NOVEMBER 2026

# How the interviewer works, and why it's built this way

The goal: talk with someone for twenty minutes, by voice, and come away with notes good enough for a digital twin to answer the way they would. It has to work for anyone, not just people who explain themselves well. Five things shaped the design. Each one started as a mistake.




The voice model does the talking. The note-taker listens, writes the notes, and suggests where to go next.

## 1 Let the voice model lead

**BEFORE** The note-taker wrote every question and the voice read it out. Replies took 2–8 seconds, and sometimes two questions came out at once.

**NOW** The voice model answers on its own, because it can hear when someone has finished. The note-taker sends a hint for the next question.

## 2 Leave behaviour to the model, not code

**BEFORE** Code rules stopped repeats, capped topics and trimmed long questions. Each one broke a normal conversation somewhere.

**NOW** The prompt describes what a good interviewer does, and the model decides. Code only moves and saves data.

## 3 Keep notes in their own words

**BEFORE** It saved labelled facts: a value, a rule, a story. Much of it was about the call ("didn't like being interrupted"), not the person.

**NOW** A small folder of short notes (work, family, views) in their words, tidied against the transcript after every call.

## 4 Ask about what makes them different

**BEFORE** In my own test call it asked five questions about how I prioritise work. Anyone would have said the same.

**NOW** It starts with what the person is known for, sketches the rest of their life, and digs only where an answer is unusual.

## 5 Make the screen calm

**BEFORE** The first screen looked like a debugging tool, and people performed for it.

**NOW** Type your name and talk. Notes appear beside the conversation as they're written. Come back later and it picks up where you left off.

## How I check a change

Ten simulated people with hidden facts are interviewed by the real system. Another model answers questions about each person from the notes alone, and a model from a different company grades the answers.

**2.0 → 2.8** areas of each person's life covered in the latest round, no facts lost

TypeScript on Cloudflare Workers · Voice: OpenAI GPT-Live · Notes: Claude Sonnet via OpenRouter

Full experiment log: THINKING.md